



TOP GUNS: Hillary with the Chatwals and other high-profile supporters; Obama (left) with the younger crowd

stops with him." SAFO, which was started by a young Indian lawyer Hrishi Karthikeyan in Washington DC, has chapters in San Francisco, New York, Seattle and Atlanta and more are being launched. Many of the young Indians are drawn to his campaign because Obama is also an immigrant and has risen through the ranks, pushing the same values as the South Asian community, working hard and achieving goals through education, says Gilda.

A recent fundraiser for Obama was nothing like the big crowd-puller organised for Hillary. It drew about 85 people, majority of whom donated small amounts. Gilda points out that the purpose of that event was to mobilise the community rather than raise funds per se. He says the average age of Obama's South Asian supporters is 25-35 and the average contributions are not more than \$100-200 (Rs 4,000-8,000) per person but the sheer volume makes up for the smaller donations. Sensing this, Obama supporters are using innovative ways to raise funds from the Indian community. The 'South Asians for Obama' website has managed to harness the power of the Internet to get bundled donations from small donors something even the ven-

erable *Washington Post* took note of. The website offers the 20-for-20 programme in which donors are challenged to raise a mere \$20 (Rs 800) each from 20 friends and family members to raise a total of \$400 (Rs 16,000). The goal is "One Lakh for Barack": 100,000 South Asian donors—50,000 in the primary campaign, and another 50,000 in the general election.

What about the Indian-American Republicans—are they anywhere in the picture? The Republican candidates are still making their intentions known and it's already a crowded field. Big donors of past years like Zach Zachariah are yet to announce whom they are supporting. Narender Reddy, who reached pioneer level in fundraising during the 2004 election and served as state vice-chair for the Bush/Cheney '04 campaign committee in Georgia, is also mulling over his choices. He has met with candidates Rudolph Giuliani and Mitt Romney, but as he says, most Indian Republicans are still undecided as to which candidate to support.

Some like Dino Teppara are clear. Being chief of staff to South Carolina's Republican Congressman and India Caucus co-chair Joe Wilson, and on the Board of Directors of the Indian American Republican Council, he has an insider's perspective. Asked which candidate is the early favourite for Indian-American Republicans, Teppara says, "Rudy Giuliani was Mayor of New York and people remember what he did after 9/11. We have a large number of Indian-Americans living in New York and New Jersey, so it is a natural constituency he can tap into. We have at least four candidates but the field has to be narrowed down."

These are early days and the political drama will only increase as the race heats up. One thing is certain—Indian-Americans are now players to be reckoned with as both first and second generation bring their skills, clout and resources to the game. Chatwal, whose aim is to raise \$5 million (Rs 20 crore) for the Clinton campaign, says, "I wanted to give a message to the rest of the politicians that don't underestimate Indian-Americans. We are very powerful—we can generate money, we can generate votes. Pay attention to us, you have no choice." The US presidential hopefuls are certainly taking note. ■

nurtured their relationship with India. He adds, "The Clintons have also been very popular in the Indian-American community over here, whereas Obama doesn't know anything about India."

Obama's young Indian supporters would beg to differ as they get started on a grassroots effort to promote their candidate amongst the South Asian community. Raj Gilda, who heads the New York chapter of South Asians for Obama (SAFO), says, "Senator Obama has apologised sincerely for the mistake of his staff member and has shown he's a mature person and that the buck